

Research Proposal Memo

To: Jennifer Mooney
From: Cassidy Calhoon, Lynn McClaffery, Lucia Lorenz, Ruhi Parikh
Subject: Positives and Negatives of AI in the Field of Creative Writing
Date: November 6, 2023

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is a new technology about which some people – primarily teachers and writers – have very mixed feelings. Some are intrigued by it, while others are afraid or uneasy about its capabilities. They fear it will eventually become so advanced that it will be able to take human jobs and make human creativity an outdated relic.

One field that is especially wary of AI is Creative Writing. What happens if artificial intelligence becomes so intelligent that it makes human writing obsolete? How can we tell whether a human wrote something or a robot wrote it? Is AI capable of being creative? And what about plagiarism? If a writer uses AI to generate ideas or work out a line of poetry or dialogue in a novel, are they plagiarizing? Can AI actually help writers? And what about the ethics of having AI help you write?

We will be looking into those questions and more for our recommendation report on how AI can be used in the field of Creative Writing and its potential benefits and threats to the profession. We hope to outline both sides of the argument and provide evidence to help those who are undecided about it choose a side. From where we stand, AI is something that is growing rapidly in intelligence and relevance. Because of this, it is important to understand it, be able to pick out when it is being used, and be able to use it to your advantage.

Project Overview and Rationale

This project is meant to analyze the overall impacts of AI on the Creative Writing industry and how these impacts can be:

- Positive or negative,
- Viewed by professionals,
- Used correctly, and
- Used as a learning aid.

In the Creative Writing field, an overwhelming number of people oppose the use of AI. Due to this, many writers are afraid to use AI for fear of being accused of plagiarism, unoriginality, or losing their jobs. While in some ways these may seem like very valid concerns, AI can also be used in safe ways that can prevent any of these outcomes.

In our report, we will address:

- The three concerns listed previously,
- Writer's views,
- And correct usage.

Concerns

The main concerns writers have, as mentioned above, are plagiarism, unoriginality, and losing their jobs. While these concerns are valid, there are correct ways to use AI that we will discuss in our report. By utilizing these, writers will have little to worry about regarding any of the three problems. While AI can be used as a creative assist, it does not plan to take over as a creative writer; even if it tried, its work would not be as lively as a human's writing.

Views

Many Creative Writers are scared of AI, though some see the potential it has as a creative aid. Creative Writers are already using it to write books and help with editing, as is Matthew Vollmer, the head of the Creative Writing Grad and Undergrad program at Virginia Tech. Later in this project it will be mentioned that we will interview Prof. Vollmer on his use of AI and opinions on using it in the classroom.

Usage

AI is good at helping authors revise and edit their stories as well as acting as an illustrator for some children's books. However it can be used for a lot more.

AI can help with:

- Content Generation and Inspiration
- Editing and Proofreading
- Market Research
- Personalized Recommendations
- Translation and Localization
- Character and Plot Development
- Research Assistance
- Natural Language Processing (NLP)
- Interactive Storytelling
- Intellectual Property Protection
- Content Distribution and Marketing
- Collaborative Writing

Because AI is a tool to help us, it has a wide range of uses. We will go into more detail about each of these uses and how to use them ethically and lawfully in our report. As an ending note, look at the bullet points, and notice that none of them insinuate that AI will take over the writing process. While "Content Generation" and "Collaborative Writing" might require giving some

credit to the AI, none of them will fully take over for the writer. AI has no ulterior motives to make our jobs unnecessary.

Project Methodology/Resources

Since this project targets the growth of AI and how it affects the creative writing industry, it is important to have reliable resources that give the most honest results.

Research Methods

The main research we will be conducting will be through interviews and databases. We plan to interview Matthew Vollmer, Professor and Director of the M.F.A. and the Undergraduate Creative Writing Program, and Joseph Trucello, assistant director of the UG Creative Writing program. Also, databases and websites that we have already found critical information on will be resources used to conduct this report.

Key Information

Below are some of the links and articles that will be used in to conduct this report:

- [“How Generative AI Is Changing Creative Work”](#) is an article that discusses the advancement of AI and how it will become a normal tool for writers to use and see in their work. But also outlines the potential problems with “content ownership and intellectual property protection” when AI is involved.
- [“How I’m Using AI to Write my Next Novel: Try This New AI Tool it Might Just Make Your Writing More Creative”](#) is an article that outlines the possibilities of using AI as a collaborative tool when writing a novel or story. It discusses the benefits that AI has when using it to help develop a storyline or plot hole.
- [“How Generative AI Could Disrupt Creative Work”](#) is an article that compares human creativity to the creativity that a Generative AI would produce. This work focused on the need for balance and understanding in the future since AI is now a part of the world.

Project Audience

Since this research topic focuses on the potential merging of AI and creative writing and how this can impact the creative writing industry in general, there is a broad audience involved, such as creative writers, of course, editors, and specifically professors here at Virginia Tech.

Matthew Vollmer

Matthew Vollmer is a writer, editor, professor, and director of the Undergraduate and Master’s in Fine Arts Creative Writing Programs here at Virginia Tech. He also has an MA from North Carolina State University and an MFA in fiction from the Iowa Writers’ Workshop. He has stated that he has used and currently uses AI for his writing, specifically Claude AI for a novel he is working on right now.

Joseph Truscello

Joseph Truscello is the Advanced Instructor and Assistant Director of the UG Creative Writing program at Virginia Tech; he teaches several courses such as Creative Writing, Fiction Workshop, and the CNF workshop. He holds an MFA from VT, an MA from Brooklyn College, and a BA from Pace University.

Project Personnel

Cassidy Calhoon is a sophomore majoring in Public Health. Although she is not in the Creative Writing field herself, she enjoys writing and reading Creative Writing and understands that writing is important to all fields, including those in Public Health.

Lynn McClafferty is a junior majoring in Creative Writing, minoring in Classical Studies, and doing an honors project on the impacts of AI on the Creative Writing industry. Although they have not used AI for their creative writing yet, they have used it on many occasions for professional writing especially email drafting.

Lucia Lorenz is a sophomore majoring in Creative Writing and Professional and Technical Writing. She has used AI as a tool to be a helpful resource for writing research papers, creating format, storybuilding, and poetry.

Ruhi Parikh is a sophomore double majoring in Creative Writing and Professional and Technical Writing. She has used AI various times to brainstorm ideas for potential stories, draft essays, and even write emails.

Project Timetable

This is our proposed timeline for the project:

Task	Start Date	End Date	Week of...					
			30-Oct	6-Nov	13-Nov	20-Nov	27-Nov	4-Dec
AI-Generated Outline	30-Oct-2023	13-Nov-2023						
Research Proposal	13-Nov-2023	27-Nov-2023						
Persuasive Technical Report	27-Nov-2023	9-Dec-2023						

Conclusion

As AI grows in popularity and in prevalence, it is important to know as much about it as we can. It is a new tool that can and will be used in all fields, including Creative Writing. For this reason, it needs to be fully understood and potentially utilized by everyone coming into contact with it. In this report, we are looking into how to use it and the pros and cons of using it.

If you have any questions, please contact me by email at cassidycalhoon@vt.edu.